AMERICAN CONTINENTAL
RAILROAD INC.

THE NEW ENGLAND MEGA-NETWORK

A unified rail system for six states, one regional economy, and the next century of mobility.

01 / MAGLEV
A conditional flagship express layer

02 / HIGH-SPEED RAIL
Fast city-to-city service on the principal spines

03 / REGIONAL & COMMUTER
Frequent all-day mobility around major employment markets

04 / RURAL & FREIGHT
Year-round access, logistics capacity and local resilience

STRATEGIC PROSPECTUS | DISCUSSION DRAFT | OCTOBER 2026

Prepared as a concept for ACRI. Not an offer to sell securities or a final engineering, ridership, cost or investment study.

01 / EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

One network, four service layers, one development strategy

ACRI should propose a New England Rail Compact: a single, integrated passenger and freight system spanning Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, Rhode Island and Vermont. It should operate as one customer network but be built in stages, using the most suitable technology for each corridor. The objective is not simply to run faster trains. It is to connect the region's labour markets, universities, hospitals, ports, airports, tourism destinations and development land into a more productive economic geography.

Core investment thesis

Build the conventional network and station districts first; make the Maglev line a separately underwritten option. ACRI earns from rail operations, logistics, stations, long-lease property, power and digital infrastructure - while public partners fund the parts whose benefits accrue broadly to the region.

The proposition in brief

DIMENSION	PROPOSAL	WHY IT MATTERS
Region	Six New England states; approximately 15.2 million residents in the 2023 estimate, before later growth. [R1]	A dense, high-income region with several separate city systems and a strong case for better intercity links.
Network form	Coastal and inland passenger spines; northward services to Maine and Canada; westward connection through Springfield to Albany; commuter and rural feeders.	Pulse hubs and timed transfers make separate corridors behave like one network.
Technology	Electrified conventional rail for most services; true HSR on selected corridors/cut-offs; Maglev only where its own demand case succeeds.	No need to force all services onto one technology or duplicate every route.
Capital envelope	Core network: roughly $210bn-$385bn; conditional Maglev option: another $75bn-$150bn; all-in programme range approximately $285bn-$535bn.	Illustrative 2026 USD planning envelope including a broad programme reserve; not an estimate suitable for procurement or investment decisions.
Commercial model	Farebox plus freight/logistics, station concessions, ground leases, property joint ventures, fibre, energy and maintenance services.	Real estate and logistics improve economics but do not remove the need for public capital.
Delivery model	Six-state compact / public infrastructure partnerships; ACRI as master planner, development integrator and contracted operator/developer.	Avoid an unfinanceable attempt to put every civil asset and every public-service obligation on one private balance sheet.

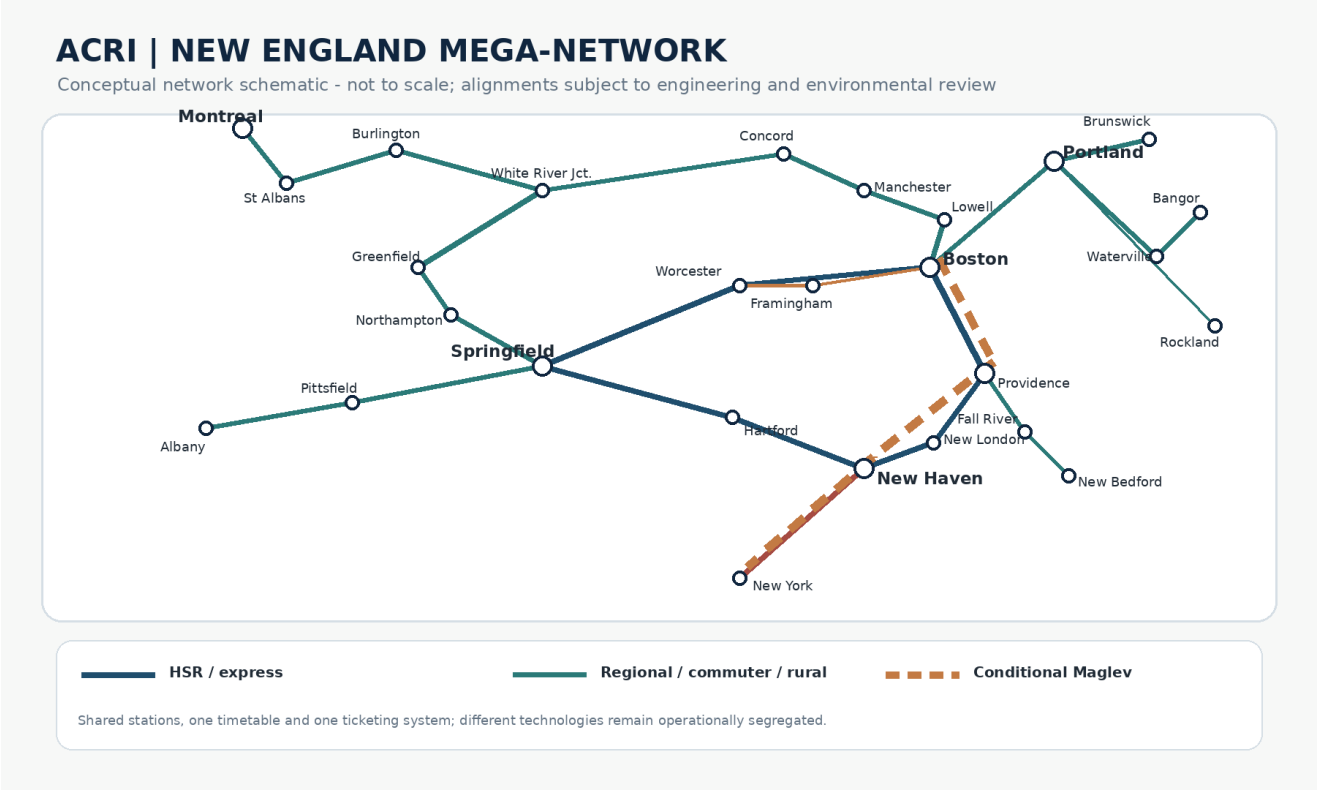
Decision requested

Authorise a 24-month corridor, property and operating-plan development phase: establish the six-state sponsor group; map all rights-of-way and freight constraints; develop a common service plan and standard station model; prepare corridor-level ridership, cost and land-value studies; and compare conventional HSR with Maglev on a like-for-like, independently audited basis. No construction commitment should be made from this prospectus alone.

02 / NETWORK ARCHITECTURE

A connected mesh - not a set of isolated lines

The map below is a concept diagram, not a surveyed alignment. The network is centred on Boston, Springfield, Hartford, New Haven and Providence, with major northern gateways at Portland, Concord, Burlington and Montreal, and a western connection through Pittsfield to Albany. ACRI should preserve the ability to serve all six states while selecting specific new-build segments only after demand, terrain, land and environmental diligence.



Network design principle: conventional rail, HSR, commuter and rural services must share wayfinding, ticketing, station access, timetable data and disruption recovery. They need not share track. Maglev is physically separate and connects into the same station districts through transfer halls.

System nodes with regional roles

Anchor hubs: Boston (gateway and air-rail integration); Worcester/Springfield (central cross-state interchange); Hartford/New Haven (Connecticut and Northeast Corridor links); Providence/T.F. Green (southern hinge and airport); Portland, Concord and Burlington/Montreal (northern gateways). Regional feeder nodes include New Bedford/Fall River, Greenfield/White River Junction and Pittsfield, where rail access can support smaller-city, rural and industrial catchments.

03 / SERVICE ARCHITECTURE

Four layers, designed around different markets

Layer A - Conventional high-speed and fast intercity rail

Use standard-gauge electric railway technology wherever possible, so services can connect directly to conventional regional tracks and established Northeast Corridor infrastructure. New 180-220 mph alignments should be limited to high-demand sections where curves, right-of-way and environmental conditions support the investment; elsewhere, upgrade for reliable 90-125 mph or faster express operation. This is a network, not a promise that every mile achieves the same top speed.

- Coastal spine: Boston - Providence - New London - New Haven, with capacity and speed improvements coordinated with the existing Northeast Corridor.
- Inland spine: Boston - Framingham - Worcester - Palmer - Springfield - Hartford - New Haven, including capacity upgrades and new cut-offs where justified.
- Northern intercity: Boston - Portland - Brunswick, with staged extension options to Augusta, Waterville, Bangor and Rockland.
- Canada / western gateways: Boston - Springfield - Northampton / Greenfield - White River Junction - Montpelier / Burlington - St Albans - Montreal; and Springfield - Pittsfield - Albany.

Layer B - Maglev: an optional premium express

The leading candidate is a new-build Boston - Providence - New Haven - New York express, providing an ultra-fast limited-stop gateway beyond New England. It would require dedicated guideway, dedicated vehicles and purpose-designed station interfaces; it cannot operate over the conventional rail tracks. The likely business case is capacity and time savings on the busiest intercity market, not a general rural or commuter mode.

Maglev phase gate

Do not include Maglev in the initial committed-capital base case. Advance it only if a comparative study shows materially better door-to-door times and capacity than conventional HSR, a credible willingness-to-pay case, acceptable environmental impacts, and a financeable cost range. If the evidence fails, ACRI should still build the conventional network.

Layer C - Regional and commuter rail

- Upgrade core commuter corridors into all-day regional rail: frequent service in both directions, electrification where justified, level boarding, modern signalling and consistent station access.
- Integrate the Boston commuter network with Providence, Worcester, Lowell, Fitchburg, Newburyport/Rockport, South Coast and other branches; extend the same operating principles to Hartford, Shore Line East, New Haven, Portland and future New Hampshire services.
- Study a Boston North-South Rail Link as a network-capacity project, not a symbolic mega-project: it should proceed only with published time-savings, capacity and lifecycle-cost evidence. Massachusetts has already examined the concept in its state rail planning. [R2]

Layer D - Rural, local and freight connectivity

- Rural rail is a year-round public service, not a once-a-day tourist train: simple clock-face schedules, accessible stations, guaranteed bus connections and timed links to hospitals, colleges and regional centres.
- Protect freight capacity through passing loops, double track, dedicated freight windows, bypasses and shared corridor planning. Do not run freight on Maglev or on dedicated high-speed tracks designed for passenger operation.
- Develop intermodal and port links around Boston, Portland, Providence, New Bedford/Fall River, Worcester, Springfield and suitable inland yards, subject to freight-owner and port agreements.

04 / CORRIDOR PORTFOLIO

Prioritise the network by connectivity and delivery readiness

ACRI should not build all corridors in parallel. The initial programme should buy the highest network benefit per dollar, establish a credible regional timetable, and unlock property nodes before committing to the most expensive greenfield sections. Existing public plans are useful building blocks, not endorsements of this complete ACRI concept.

PRIORITY	CORRIDOR	SCOPE	PRIORITY LEVEL	DELIVERY LOGIC
1. Coastal core	Boston - Providence - New London - New Haven	Reliability, capacity, station access, bottleneck relief and selected speed improvements.	High	Build on existing NEC and state planning; preserve express slots.
2. Inland core	Boston - Worcester - Palmer - Springfield - Hartford - New Haven	Freight-compatible capacity, double-track where needed, electrification and targeted curve/grade work.	High	MassDOT is developing Boston-Albany / Inland Route planning and an initial Springfield-Worcester service increment. [R3]
3. Northern coast	Boston - Haverhill - Dover - Portland - Brunswick	Increase frequency and reliability; new passing capacity; evaluate faster bypasses.	High	Downeaster already connects the corridor; extension and extra service options exist in planning. [R4]
4. Southern New England feeders	Providence / Boston to New Bedford, Fall River and other branches	Reliable commuter/regional service with transfer-friendly station design.	High-Medium	Build around known station and branch investments; align with land-use permissions.
5. Vermont / Canada	Springfield - Greenfield - White River Junction - Burlington / St Albans - Montreal	Restore frequency, improve track, add passing capacity and border-ready through service.	Medium	Phased upgrade; international cooperation and border procedures are essential. [R5]
6. New Hampshire arc	Boston - Lowell - Manchester - Concord; connections to Portland	Route protection, feasibility, service development and station-area planning.	Medium	New service is subject to rights-of-way, environmental review and demand work.
7. Western connection	Springfield - Pittsfield - Albany	Improved intercity service and direct Boston/western Massachusetts connection.	Medium	Coordinate with the Boston-Albany Corridor and host-freight operations. [R3]

PRIORITY	CORRIDOR	SCOPE	PRIORITY LEVEL	DELIVERY LOGIC
8. Maglev express	Boston - Providence - New Haven - New York	Dedicated premium service with a distinct guideway and station halls.	Conditional	No full construction approval until comparative appraisal and demand gates are passed.

Indicative passenger proposition

MARKET	SERVICE TARGET AT MATURITY	CUSTOMER PROMISE
Urban / commuter core	Every 15-30 minutes on strongest corridors at peak; every 30-60 minutes off-peak.	Useful without consulting a timetable; reliable two-way travel.
Regional cities	Hourly or better on main corridors, with early-morning and late-evening services.	Same-day access to jobs, hospitals, universities and airports.
Northern / rural branches	At least 4-8 useful round trips daily on designated core rural corridors, adjusted to demand.	A practical alternative to driving; connections guaranteed.
Intercity express	Clock-face departures, coordinated with commuter pulses and Northeast Corridor slots.	Predictable travel times and one ticket across operators.
Maglev (if approved)	Limited-stop peak and off-peak express pattern, designed around measured market demand.	Premium speed, with easy transfer to HSR and regional trains.

05 / CUSTOMER AND OPERATING MODEL

Make the network feel like one railway

One timetable and ticket, many operators where needed

The customer should be able to search and book a trip from a rural Vermont town to Logan Airport, or from Portland to New Haven, as a single itinerary. ACRI should provide a shared digital layer even where states, Amtrak, commuter authorities and private operators retain different legal operating roles.

- Common fare product: through-ticketing, fare capping for local travel, transparent seat reservations on intercity services and disruption protection across connections.
- Pulse scheduling at major hubs: arrivals cluster before departures, with sensible transfer buffers. The exact pulses are established by simulation after timetable and infrastructure constraints are known.
- A common passenger standard: accessible platforms, clear signage, consistent passenger information, real-time disruption alerts, clean washrooms, secure bicycle storage and staffed help at regional hubs.
- Open data and interoperable APIs for trip planners, municipalities, employers, hotels, universities and freight customers.
- Operations control centre: dispatching coordination, incident response, rolling-stock allocation, weather alerts, line capacity management and a network-wide service recovery plan.

Engineering standards

ASSET / SYSTEM	ACRI STANDARD	REASON
Conventional passenger rail	Standard gauge; modern electric traction where lifecycle economics justify it; compatible with US regulatory and operating requirements.	Enables through-running on compatible conventional tracks and reduces fleet fragmentation.
HSR lines	Dedicated, fully grade-separated tracks for the fastest services; 25 kV AC is a planning option to test through engineering design.	Safety, reliable high-speed operation and capacity separation from freight.
Maglev	Dedicated guideway, rolling system and stations; no assumption of physical interoperability with conventional rail.	Keeps the Maglev option technically honest and prevents incompatible systems from contaminating the base plan.
Signalling and control	Digitally supervised train control, modern interlocking, central traffic management and common passenger information.	Capacity and reliability depend on the whole operating system, not just top speed.
Climate resilience	Flood, heat, snow, saltwater, slope and storm-surge standards by corridor; redundant power and critical spares.	New England weather and coastal exposure must be designed into long-lived assets.
Fleet and maintenance	Standardised families, regional depots, predictive maintenance, common parts catalogue where possible.	Higher availability and lower whole-life maintenance cost.

Freight is a separate commercial discipline

Freight should use conventional track and purpose-built logistics facilities, coordinated with passenger timetables rather than squeezed into HSR infrastructure. ACRI should seek long-term capacity and dispatch agreements with current corridor owners and operators, and should price terminal, access and handling services independently. Massachusetts' freight plan treats rail, truck, maritime and intermodal movement as one freight system, a model ACRI should adopt region-wide. [R6]

06 / VERTICAL INTEGRATION AND LAND

The railway is also a property, logistics and utilities platform

The defining commercial advantage of ACRI should be the ability to plan track, stations, surrounding land, yards, power and passenger demand together. This does not mean speculative land hoarding or assuming the company owns every right-of-way. It means controlling selected land and development rights through purchase, long leases, joint ventures, air rights and public development agreements where those assets can help fund the transport system.

BUSINESS LINE	ASSETS / ACTIVITIES	REVENUE MECHANISM	STRATEGIC ROLE
Rail infrastructure & operations	Track access contracts, stations, fleet, control centres and maintenance.	Operating contracts, availability payments, access charges, fares where concession allows.	Core network reliability and operating discipline.

BUSINESS LINE	ASSETS / ACTIVITIES	REVENUE MECHANISM	STRATEGIC ROLE
Stations & property	Station air rights, ground leases, mixed-use districts, retail, hotels, offices and housing.	Ground rent, development JV profits, retail leases, station concessions, parking.	Capture part of the land value created by improved access.
Freight & logistics	Intermodal yards, warehouses, transload facilities, terminal access and industrial parks.	Handling fees, leases, freight access and logistics services.	Use rail land and network capacity for private-sector cargo demand.
Power & energy	Traction substations, microgrids where suitable, storage, PPAs and depot electrification.	Energy management services and contracted supply margins.	Reduce exposure to energy volatility and improve resilience.
Digital infrastructure	Fibre routes, station connectivity, rail data products and operational technology services.	Fibre leases, connectivity, data services and service contracts.	Monetise corridor infrastructure without compromising rail safety.
Manufacturing & lifecycle	Vehicle refurbishment, parts depots, track equipment and supplier development.	Maintenance contracts, component supply and overhaul revenue.	Improve fleet availability and build a regional rail supply chain.

Station district investment strategy

- Classify every station into one of four types: gateway hub, city-centre interchange, suburban growth node or rural access point. Each type gets a different design and property model.
- Use compact, walkable development around higher-frequency stations: housing, workplaces, education, clinics, hotels and daily services. Density should follow service frequency, not precede it blindly.
- Prioritise brownfields, existing rail land and underused commercial property. Make land acquisition transparent and avoid relying on involuntary acquisition of private homes for speculative development.
- Use long ground leases and joint ventures where public partners want to retain ownership. ACRI can earn cash returns while retaining the public interest in strategic station land.
- Publish community benefit agreements: affordable housing targets where applicable, local hiring, pedestrian/bicycle links, public realm and access for rural communities.

Important accounting separation

Keep regulated rail infrastructure, public-service operations and commercial property in separate subsidiaries with clear transfer prices and audited accounts. This stops property gains from disguising weak railway economics and lets investors price each business on its own merits.

Asset target for diligence, not a current holding

A first-stage study should catalogue a potential portfolio of 30-50 strategic station and logistics districts, then determine which sites ACRI could legally control, lease or develop. Any acreage target, land valuation or development profit remains unverified until parcel-level ownership, zoning, environmental condition, access rights and community impacts have been assessed.

07 / CAPITAL PLAN

Build in tranches; do not underwrite the entire map at once

The capital range below is a strategic envelope in constant 2026 US dollars, not an engineering estimate. It includes a broad programme-level reserve within the range but excludes financing costs and inflation escalation. It intentionally reflects the uncertainty in tunnelling, viaducts, urban approaches, land acquisition, bridge replacement, environmental mitigation and the Maglev guideway. The programme must be re-estimated corridor by corridor at successive design stages.

CAPITAL CATEGORY	ORDER-OF-MAGNITUDE RANGE	STATUS
Existing network rehabilitation, electrification, signalling and resilience	$45bn-$75bn	Core
New HSR lines, bypasses and express cut-offs	$60bn-$110bn	Core
Regional / commuter capacity, fleet and Boston North-South Rail Link option	$25bn-$45bn	Core
Rural branch restoration and new feeder connections	$8bn-$18bn	Core
Stations, yards, depots, fleet systems, freight interfaces, power and digital backbone	$15bn-$30bn	Core
Station-district enabling infrastructure and selective property investment	$15bn-$30bn	Core
Subtotal core programme before reserve	$168bn-$308bn	Core
Programme risk reserve (approx. 25% of component envelope)	Included in all-in range	Core
Indicative core programme all-in range	$210bn-$385bn	Core
Conditional Maglev guideway, vehicles, stations and systems	$60bn-$120bn	Option
Maglev-specific risk reserve (approx. 25%)	Included in all-in range	Option
Conditional Maglev all-in option	$75bn-$150bn	Option
TOTAL PROGRAMME IF MAGLEV PROCEEDS	$285bn-$535bn	All-in

Why the range is wide

- Costs are determined by the alignment and the proportion of tunnels, viaducts, difficult urban approaches and protected land, not simply by route mileage.
- The California High-Speed Rail Authority's 2025 comparative review reported roughly $46m/mile average cost for selected European comparison projects and about $133m/mile where tunnelling and viaducts were extensive. Those are benchmarks, not direct estimates for New England or Maglev. [R7]
- New England requires separate treatment of freight rights, grade crossings, coastal resilience, commuter interfaces, historic districts, wetlands and mountain terrain.
- Programme totals may shift materially after station choice, service patterns, right-of-way ownership, Maglev scope and private property participation are settled.

Investment gates

GATE	REQUIRED EVIDENCE	STOP / REDESIGN RULE
Gate 0: network concept	Demand map, assets/owners, environmental constraints, service plan and options analysis.	No corridor enters design without a stated purpose and credible alternative.
Gate 1: service development	Timetable simulation, ridership forecast, operating plan, freight interaction and preliminary cost range.	Reject proposals whose benefits depend on unrealistic travel times or ridership.
Gate 2: reference design	Surveyed alignment, utility relocations, land strategy, lifecycle cost and delivery packaging.	Re-scope if cost growth exceeds contingency or impacts cannot be mitigated.
Gate 3: funding close	Committed public funding, debt terms, equity, land agreements, permits and risk allocation.	No construction notice-to-proceed on unfunded scope.
Gate 4: independent assurance	Third-party cost review, safety case, updated demand downside and benefit-cost ratio.	Maglev does not proceed unless it beats the conventional alternative.

08 / COMMERCIAL MODEL AND RETURNS

The farebox is necessary; it is not the whole investment case

At this capital scale, ACRI must not promise private-equity railway returns from fares alone. Regional and rural mobility delivers public benefits that are not fully monetised in ticket prices. A credible prospectus therefore combines public capital for broad-benefit infrastructure, contractual revenue for service delivery, privately financed commercial assets, and disciplined sequencing. Land-value capture improves the case; it does not make every line self-financing.

Illustrative mature annual operating scenarios

The following is a screening model only. It is not a ridership forecast or valuation. It assumes the full conventional network is operating and station/property assets have been developed. The Maglev option would need its own standalone model and is not required for the base case.

MEASURE	CONSERVATIVE	BASE SCREEN	UPSIDE
Annual passenger journeys	100m	150m	200m
Passenger fare revenue	$2.0bn	$3.2bn	$4.6bn
Freight and logistics revenue	$0.4bn	$0.7bn	$1.0bn
Station commercial / advertising	$0.35bn	$0.55bn	$0.80bn
Net property operating income	$0.60bn	$1.25bn	$2.00bn
Power, fibre, maintenance and other	$0.15bn	$0.25bn	$0.40bn
TOTAL RECURRING REVENUE / NOI	$3.50bn	$5.95bn	$8.80bn
Operating and routine maintenance cost	($3.8bn)	($4.6bn)	($5.8bn)
SURPLUS BEFORE MAJOR RENEWALS, DEBT AND TAX	($0.30bn)	$1.35bn	$3.00bn

Financial caution: the base-screen surplus is only about 0.3%-0.5% of a $285bn-$535bn all-in system envelope before major renewals, financing costs, tax and debt service. The high-capital programme cannot be financed on a standard private concession return from operating cash alone. The capital structure must place public-benefit civil works with public sponsors, while private capital focuses on revenue-bearing concessions, rolling stock, logistics, power and property.

Where returns should come from

RETURN ENGINE	WHAT ACRI CAN EARN	UNDERWRITING REQUIREMENT
Operating contracts	Service payments, performance incentives, passenger fares where contracted, station access and maintenance.	Contracts indexed for labour/energy, clear service specifications, realistic availability and performance deductions.
Logistics / freight	Terminal leases, handling, transload, intermodal services, rail access and industrial property.	Freight customer contracts and capacity agreements; no assumption that passenger tracks are available for freight.
Real estate	Ground rent, retail leases, hotel/office/housing development profits and selective asset sales.	Parcel-level title, zoning and market study; independent valuations and transparent joint ventures.
Energy and digital	Fibre leases, traction energy management, depot charging, station connectivity and maintenance data.	Ring-fenced business plans and no disruption to safety-critical operations.
Public-benefit capital	Grants, capital contributions, availability payments and low-cost public debt for eligible infrastructure.	Government commitments, eligible scope and measurable public outcomes - not implicit guarantees.

Financing architecture

- Use a public infrastructure company or six-state compact for major right-of-way and civil works; ACRI competes to design, integrate, operate or maintain defined packages.
- Use separate project companies for major HSR corridors, station districts, freight terminals and energy assets. Avoid cross-collateralising unproven Maglev with the core commuter network.
- Structure private capital against contracted cash flows and property assets rather than assuming the whole system can support commercial project-finance debt.
- Stage land acquisition after service commitments and zoning pathways are clear; release capital only as development rights and infrastructure delivery progress.

09 / DELIVERY ROADMAP

A 25-year programme with early proof points

The recommended strategy is to create a functioning regional railway early, then add speed and capacity where the network proves demand. Delivering a full high-speed grid and a Maglev line simultaneously would magnify land, funding, governance and delivery risks before ACRI has a track record.

PERIOD	PHASE	KEY DELIVERABLES	CAPITAL DISCIPLINE
2027-2028	Organise and design	Create the multi-state sponsor group; corridor inventory; rights-of-way audit; passenger/freight timetable; station district shortlist; common data/ticketing architecture; independent reference cost plan.	No major construction commitment.
2028-2032	No-regrets first increment	Advance service increases, station accessibility, signalling, passing capacity, reliability projects, rolling-stock procurement and the most valuable freight interfaces. Coordinate with existing funded corridor programmes.	Demonstrate on-time performance and ridership response.
2030-2037	Regional frequency grid	Build all-day regional/commuter service on core corridors; improve Boston-Worcester-Springfield and Hartford-Springfield connections; extend northern service; start station district JVs where land is ready.	Revenue service begins in tranches; publish annual performance.
2034-2043	HSR and express cut-offs	Construct the best-performing dedicated HSR sections and grade-separated bottleneck bypasses; integrate the coastal and inland express services.	Each segment must pass cost, demand and benefit-cost gates.

PERIOD	PHASE	KEY DELIVERABLES	CAPITAL DISCIPLINE
2038-2048	Northern and rural network	Expand Vermont/Canada links, New Hampshire arc, Maine extensions and rural feeders as demand, track rights and environmental permits permit.	Public-service obligations defined; no unfunded rural operating promises.
2040-2052+	Maglev decision and possible build	Complete an independent comparison with HSR, verify demand, land and guideway cost; if approved, deliver as a separate project company.	If the case does not beat conventional HSR, defer or cancel Maglev.

Programme control

- One network plan office sets technical interfaces, station standards, passenger information and corridor sequencing; individual project companies retain delivery accountability.
- Independent cost and schedule assurance reports directly to public sponsors and the ACRI board, not solely to the project delivery team.
- Fixed-price contracts only where design maturity and risk allocation make them credible; otherwise use target-cost contracts with open-book reporting and pain/gain sharing.
- Report quarterly on schedule, cost, change orders, safety, community impacts, ridership, punctuality and property commitments.
- Keep freight operators, municipalities, tribal governments, environmental agencies, unions, universities and port authorities involved before alignment freeze.

The first 24 months: tangible outputs

WORKSTREAM	OUTPUT	OWNER / PARTNER
Network engineering	Corridor atlas, bottleneck model, standard designs, staging plan and integrated timetable.	ACRI programme office + rail operators + state DOTs.
Commercial diligence	Ridership and fare model by OD pair, freight demand, operating contracts and fleet plan.	ACRI commercial team + independent transport economists.
Property strategy	Parcel register, title/zoning/environmental diligence, station-area masterplans and community agreements.	ACRI property subsidiary + municipalities + landowners.
Funding and governance	Six-state compact options, federal eligibility, public/private risk allocation and project-company structure.	State sponsors + federal partners + financial advisers.
Maglev comparison	Like-for-like appraisal of conventional HSR, Maglev and demand management; concept alignment and sensitivity tests.	Independent engineering, cost and ridership teams.

One regional compact, clear commercial accountability

The six states would need a durable mechanism to coordinate routes, service standards, fare policy, environmental review and funding. Federal Railroad Administration corridor programmes explicitly contemplate state groups, interstate compacts and regional rail authorities as eligible corridor sponsors; this provides a governance route to investigate, not a pre-approval of the ACRI programme. [R8]

Recommended structure

ENTITY	ROLE	BOUNDARY
New England Rail Compact / public sponsor	Sets network objectives, public-service obligations, integration standards, capital priorities and performance reporting.	Does not substitute for environmental review, appropriation or project-level approvals.
ACRI Network Integrator	Master planner; design interface management; concession bidder; shared ticketing, data and customer standards.	No automatic right to own public corridors or displace existing operators.
Corridor project companies	Deliver defined civil works, rolling stock, operating services or maintenance under specific contracts.	Each project has separate budget, risks, schedule and independent assurance.
ACRI Stations & Districts	Property development, ground leases, station retail and urban design with local partners.	Separate accounts, independent valuations, community commitments and transparent transactions.
ACRI Freight & Logistics	Terminals, intermodal sites and agreed freight services.	Freight rights, capacity, safety and host-railroad agreements respected.
Independent technical / public auditor	Cost, schedule, ridership, safety, access, affordability and benefits audit.	Reports publicly at regular intervals.

Principal risks and the response

RISK	LEVEL	MITIGATION
Capital overrun / scope creep	Very high	Use stage gates, reference designs, independent cost reviews, controlled scope and published contingency usage.
Fragmented ownership and access rights	High	Start with a corridor-by-corridor title, dispatching, freight and lease inventory; negotiate before alignment freeze.
Maglev technology / interface risk	High	Separate company and funding; independent HSR comparator; do not make core-network benefits depend on it.
Demand and fare risk	High	Model origin-destination markets; use conservative base case; begin with frequency and reliability improvements before maximum-speed build.

RISK	LEVEL	MITIGATION
Environmental / community impact	High	Compare alternatives; favour existing rail corridors and brownfields where sensible; publish mitigation and community benefit agreements.
Rural service economics	Medium-High	Define public-service contracts and service floors; connect by timed feeder bus; do not hide operating subsidy.
Freight conflict	High	Add capacity and separate passenger fast tracks; use binding host-railroad service and dispatch agreements.
Property speculation / displacement	High	Transparent land policy, public-interest covenants, independent valuations and local housing/community targets.
Climate and resilience	High	Engineer to corridor-specific flood, heat, snow, slope, saltwater and storm scenarios; include lifecycle maintenance.
Political discontinuity	High	Use multi-year statutory compact, published milestones and benefit-sharing across states; maintain viable independent phases.

Public-value contract

Public support should be conditional on measurable outcomes: reliability, frequency, travel-time reduction, rural access, station accessibility, freight reliability, housing capacity around selected stations, emissions performance and local workforce training. Report the results annually. ACRI should be commercially disciplined but not pretend that a rural service is profitable merely because its subsidy is placed in another subsidiary.

11 / INVESTMENT DECISION

The credible ambition is bigger than the first contract

ACRI can differentiate itself by acting as an integrated network developer rather than a train operator bidding one route at a time. Its advantage would be the coordination of the timetable, the right-of-way, the stations, the freight terminal, the power system and the development district. But scale only creates value if the company sequences investment and makes each layer financeable on its own merits.

What should be approved now

- Approve a 24-month planning and development mandate for the six-state network concept, subject to sponsor participation and budget limits.
- Commission an independent corridor inventory: track ownership, rights, freight use, capacity, bridge/tunnel condition, environmental constraints, station catchments and existing public project commitments.

- Develop a single operating concept with service frequencies, rolling-stock requirements, timed interchange, through-ticketing and a customer performance standard.
- Create an integrated commercial model with separate accounts for public infrastructure, passenger operations, freight/logistics, property and utilities.
- Build a parcel-level station-area portfolio only after public access, zoning, environmental condition and community effects are assessed.
- Commission an independent Maglev-versus-conventional-HSR appraisal with a firm decision gate. No Maglev construction commitment in the initial base case.
- Prepare grant, concession, public-private partnership and private property-finance structures corridor by corridor, without assuming any funding award or government guarantee.

Investment committee conclusion

Proceed with the integrated network development phase. Do not yet approve the full $285bn-$535bn capital programme. Make the core conventional rail and regional service plan the investable foundation; use station property and freight as complementary revenue engines; and retain Maglev as a high-potential, high-risk option that must earn its place.

Illustrative performance indicators

PILLAR	MEASURES TO PUBLISH
Passenger	Annual journeys, farebox recovery by service class, punctuality, cancellations, average transfer time, customer satisfaction and accessibility.
Infrastructure	Capital cost to date, forecast cost at completion, schedule variance, asset condition, incident rate and renewal backlog.
Freight	On-time arrival, terminal dwell, available paths, tonnage/intermodal units, customer retention and corridor conflicts.
Property	Leased occupancy, recurring NOI, housing/jobs enabled, public-realm delivery, affordability commitments and realised land proceeds.
Public value	Travel-time savings, rural access, reliability, mode shift, emissions, workforce training and economic activity near stations.
Finance	Revenue by segment, operating surplus before renewals, debt-service coverage by project, subsidy per service class and contingent liabilities.

APPENDIX / EVIDENCE BASE

Sources and planning references

The sources below establish that several component corridors and planning mechanisms already exist. They do not validate the full ACRI network, its capital cost, ridership, property strategy or projected returns. All ACRI-specific figures in this prospectus are illustrative assumptions developed for concept planning.

R1 U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, New England Regional Report, 1Q 2024. Reports New England population estimate of about 15.16 million as of July 1, 2023, sourced from the U.S. Census Bureau. Source link

R2 Massachusetts Department of Transportation, State Rail Plan; includes long-term network planning and North-South Rail Link feasibility discussion. Source link

R3 Massachusetts Department of Transportation, Boston & Albany Corridor project; Corridor ID and service development status. Source link

R4 Massachusetts Department of Transportation, Inland Route intercity passenger rail service; planned Springfield-Worcester infrastructure and freight-compatible capacity improvements. Source link

R5 Connecticut Department of Transportation, Hartford Line Improvements - Regional Vision; regional passenger rail connections and planning corridors. Source link

R6 Massachusetts Department of Transportation, Freight Plan; multi-modal framing of rail, truck, maritime and intermodal transport. Source link

R7 California High-Speed Rail Authority, 2025 Supplemental Project Update Report; international comparator costs and discussion of tunnelling/viaduct cost differences. Source link

R8 Federal Railroad Administration, Corridor Identification and Development Program; eligible applicants include states, groups of states, interstate compacts and regional rail authorities. Source link

R9 Federal Railroad Administration, Northern New England Intercity Rail Initiative blueprint; historic planning for Boston-New Haven through Springfield and Boston-Montreal connections. Source link

R10 Federal Railroad Administration, NEC FUTURE Final EIS; integrated Northeast Corridor and connecting-corridor planning, including Hartford/Springfield, Vermont and Inland Route context. Source link

R11 Amtrak, FY 2024 Year-End Ridership Fact Sheet; reported route-level ridership and national demand context. Source link

R12 Federal Railroad Administration, Federal-State Partnership for Intercity Passenger Rail programme; eligible capital investment categories and funding structure context. Source link

Important assumptions and disclosures

This document is a strategic concept prospectus for discussion only. American Continental Railroad Inc. is treated here as the proposed sponsor of a hypothetical programme; this document does not assert that ACRI owns any railway, land, franchise or operating licence. Routes are conceptual and subject to survey, environmental review, host railroad agreements, community consultation and government approvals. Costs are broad order-of-magnitude ranges in constant 2026 USD; they are not estimates prepared to an engineering standard. Revenue and operating scenarios are illustrative sensitivities, not forecasts. Ridership, fares, costs, programme dates, property income, financing, grants, returns and public benefits may vary materially. There is no offer, solicitation or recommendation to buy securities. ACRI should obtain independent engineering, legal, environmental, tax, ridership, cost and investment advice before making commitments.